



BEFORE

The Opium Wars of the mid-19th century were the culmination of more than 50 years of strained Anglo-Chinese relations.

THE LADY HUGHES

In 1784 a British merchant ship, the *Lady Hughes*, fired a cannon salute and **accidentally killed two Chinese officials**. Chinese law required that whoever was responsible should be surrendered to the authorities. The gunner was reluctantly handed over, and he was immediately strangled. Thereafter, Westerners **refused to submit to Chinese law**.

THE MACARTNEY EMBASSY

In 1792, **Lord Macartney** led a large British delegation to the summer palace of **Emperor Qianlong** at Rehe to request the accreditation of a British minister at court, the opening of more ports, and the provision of an island base. He was granted an audience but **refused to perform the kotow**, the respectful ceremonial three prostrations and nine head knockings. Qianlong accepted Macartney's gifts but **rejected all the envoy's requests**.

The Opium Wars

By 1838, use of opium, a highly addictive drug, was spiraling out of control in China. Increasingly concerned by the British trafficking of the narcotic, the Chinese government took prohibitive action, leading to a series of conflicts between the two countries.



Opium smoking

Opium imports were sanctioned under the 1858 Treaty of Tianjin and, in consequence, opium growing and addiction to the drug spread throughout China. In 1906, opium cultivation was finally banned and opium dens were forced to close. The apparatus for opium smoking was confiscated and burned in public bonfires.

In an attempt to curb the opium problem, the Chinese government appointed a leading official, Lin Zexu, to suppress trade in Guangzhou, a port city in the south of the country. On his arrival, Lin confiscated all opium stocks, and forced foreign residents to sign a bond agreeing to stop trading in the drug. The British government, having learned that its citizens had been imprisoned, sent an expeditionary force to China.

This force blockaded Guangzhou and, moving north, threatened the capital Beijing. Negotiations followed that left neither side satisfied. In 1842, a larger expeditionary force brought about a Chinese surrender, ending the First Opium War. China was compelled to

negotiate the Treaty of Nanjing (see right), which ceded Hong Kong to Britain, admitted missionaries, controlled external tariffs, opened five treaty ports, and removed Westerners from Chinese jurisdiction. However, the relationship between Britain and

Sword used in Opium Wars

The outcome of the conflict between Britain and China was largely determined by weaponry. Chinese swords—like this example, captured by a British naval officer in 1842—were no match for British firearms.

